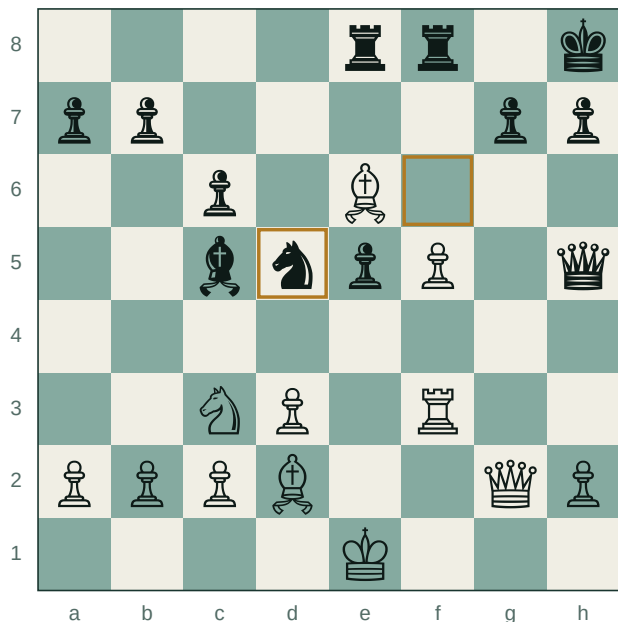


Trapping a piece: White, move 21

Trapping a piece

White to move



Previous move: 20...Nd5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

21. Rh3 Bf2+ 22. Kxf2 Qxh3 23. Qxh3

21.Rh3 The rook moves from f3 to h3. The changed line means the queen on g2 attacks the knight on d5. Recorded reply: **21...Bf2+**.

22.Kxf2 The king captures the bishop on f2. Recorded reply: **22...Qxh3**.

23.Qxh3 The queen captures the queen on h3.

At the end, nominal material is White 24 / Black 19 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +7. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +7: the balance goes from -2 to +5. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attacked piece is not trapped if it can give check, trade itself favorably, or open an escape through a sacrifice.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A trapped piece lacks safe retreat squares. Winning it usually requires restricting its routes before attacking it, or forcing it into a cage.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace every plausible escape square for the target, including captures and counterchecks. Then find the move that closes the remaining route.

The defending king is on h8. Geometrically undefended: queen on h5 and bishop on c5. Check for tactical protection.